toons bearing the broom symbol flutter everywhere. Large banners with pictures of the AAP supremo have cropped up. A loudspeaker plays the iconic revolutionary song '*Mera Rang De Basanti Chola*'. Kejriwal doubles down on the subject of his incarceration. "I missed you all while in jail. But yesterday a miracle happened and the Supreme Court freed me to campaign in front of you today," he says, as the crowd cheers him on.

Of course, like all political rallies, this too is somewhat choreographed. The AAP has no dearth of ground troops in Delhi to help put up a show of strength whenever it wants. In the South Delhi Lok Sabha constituency, the AAP won nine out of the 10 assembly seats in the 2020 state polls barely a year after the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) swept the general election and with it all the seven parliamentary seats in Delhi. But when on March 21, Kejriwal became the first-ever chief minister to be arrested while in office, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) probing the Delhi excise policy case unwittingly gave the AAP a narrative to build on in the election season.

Just over a decade old, the AAP has never been in the race to form the government at the Centre and was not even seen as the principal Opposition party. The people of Delhi, therefore, have found no reason to vote for it in parliamentary elections. In 2019, the BJP secured 56.6 per cent of the votes in Delhi. The Congress was a distant second, garnering a 22.5 per cent vote share, while the AAP languished at just 18.1 per cent. However, the same electorate gave the AAP 62 of Delhi's 70 assembly seats with a 53.6 per cent vote share the very next year. "This time, the people are angry," claims Mahabal Mishra, AAP's Lok Sabha candidate in the West Delhi seat. "The BJP has put the Delhi CM in jail without any evidence or any basis. I can feel this sentiment in people everywhere I go for campaigning."

Kejriwal's temporary release from jail assumes significance as it comes right in the middle of the general election. The two states that the party rules—Delhi and Punjab—are going to vote on May 25 and June 1, respectively. AAP is also in the fray in a few seats in Gujarat and Haryana, having fielded a

"I WILL TOUR THE ENTIRE COUNTRY AND FIGHT TO SAVE MY NATION AGAINST DICTATORSHIP. *MERE KHOON KA EK EK QATRA MERE DESH KE NAAM QURBAAN HAI*"

Arvind Kejriwal
National Convenor, AAP, and Chief Minister, Delhi



"THERE ARE ONLY TWO ELECTORAL ISSUES IN DELHI- KEJRIWAL'S CORRUPTION AND 10 YEARS OF DEVELOPMENT CARRIED OUT BY PM MODI"

Virendra Sachdeva
President, Delhi BJP

20 candidates across the four states. The party supremo's presence will certainly give a boost to the AAP's campaign, as he is not only its face but also the chief strategist. Kejriwal is expected to bolster the campaign of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) in other states too, being among the most popular Opposition leaders. More importantly, the INDIA bloc hopes to gain from the public sympathy generated by his arrest, having labelled it as the BJP's attempt to suppress the voice of the Opposition.

Right after Kejriwal was arrested, his party, not sure whether he would be out in time for canvassing, devised its whole campaign strategy around it, coining the slogan '*Jail ka jawaab vote se*'. The beauty of the slogan, AAP functionaries claim, is that it remains valid even after Kejriwal is out of jail, by posing a call to action to its core voters. Before his bail, the party enlisted Kejriwal's wife Sunita for over a month to hold massive road shows and invoke Delhi's love for its "son, brother" who was "unjustly victimised". In the rallies, a solemn-faced Sunita would say: "They jailed my husband because they are jealous of your love for him." A poll plank that has emotion, development and anti-establishmentarianism all rolled into one.

Tugging at Delhiites' heartstrings aside, what makes the AAP somewhat confident despite the odds is the simple arithmetic of alliance. With the AAP and the Congress inking a seat-sharing pact in Delhi, Haryana and Gujarat, the INDIA bloc has fielded united candidates in Delhi's seven seats. The AAP has got four of those in its share—South Delhi, West Delhi, New Delhi and East Delhi. The Congress has got three—North East Delhi, North West Delhi and Chandni Chowk. No such arrangement could be reached in Punjab, where both parties are vying for all 13 seats. But in Delhi, the two have created a coordination committee to oversee the smooth transfer of votes, even as the 2019 numbers show that their combined vote share (40.6 per cent) was nowhere close to the BJP's 56.6 per cent. "We are in this together," says Congress's North East Delhi candidate Kanhaiya Kumar. "[Kejriwal's] bail is a befitting reply to those who want to kill democracy and bring in *taanashahi* (dictatorship) in this country."

Kejriwal's interim bail will last 21 days, until June 1, after which he has to surrender. The apex court has allowed him this relief only to campaign. And he is leaving no stone unturned to milk this opportunity. In response to the BJP's poll promises titled 'Modi ki Guarantee', he has come out with 'Kejriwal's 10 guarantees'. They carry the usual tropes from the AAP playbook, like free electricity, education and health care, full statehood to Delhi, and a crackdown on corruption. The AAP chief is holding multiple rallies in Delhi. He also campaigned in Kurukshetra where the party has fielded its lone Haryana candidate. With an eye on Punjab, he keeps Punjab